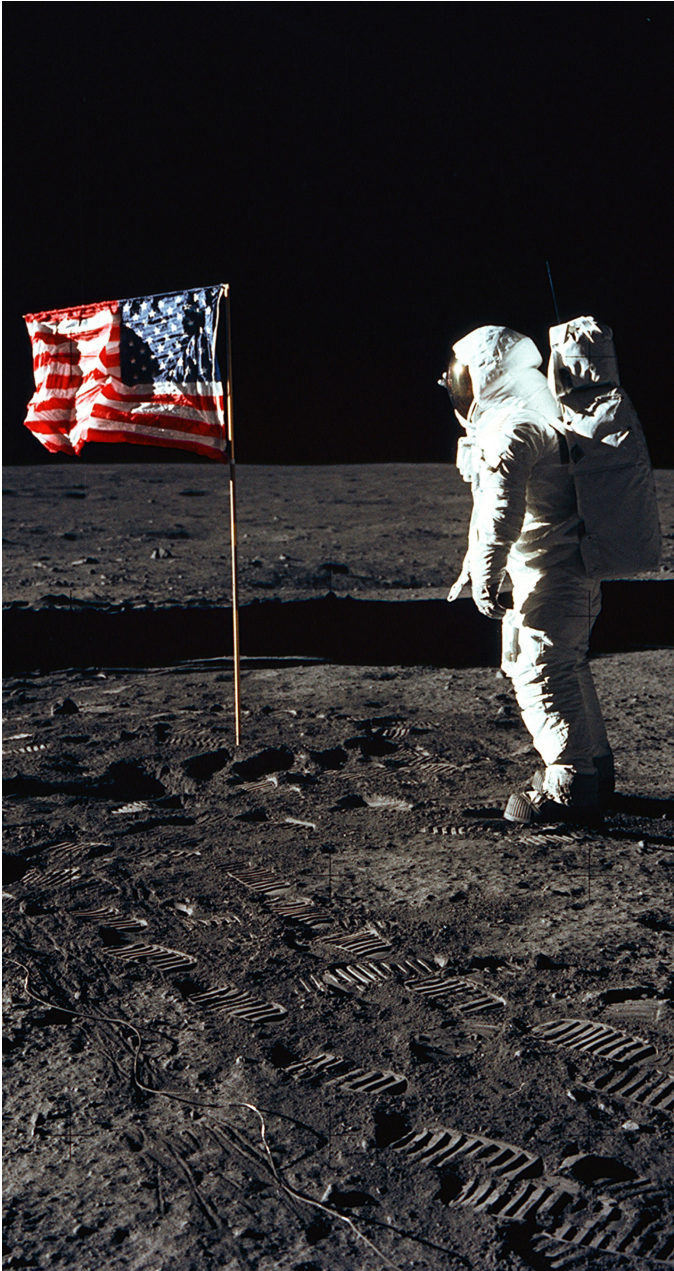


Dark Secrets Conspiracy Theories

Conspiracy theorists believe that the official version of events told to the public is actually a lie. They think the powers that be are lying or covering up facts to manipulate the population.

The Moon Landings

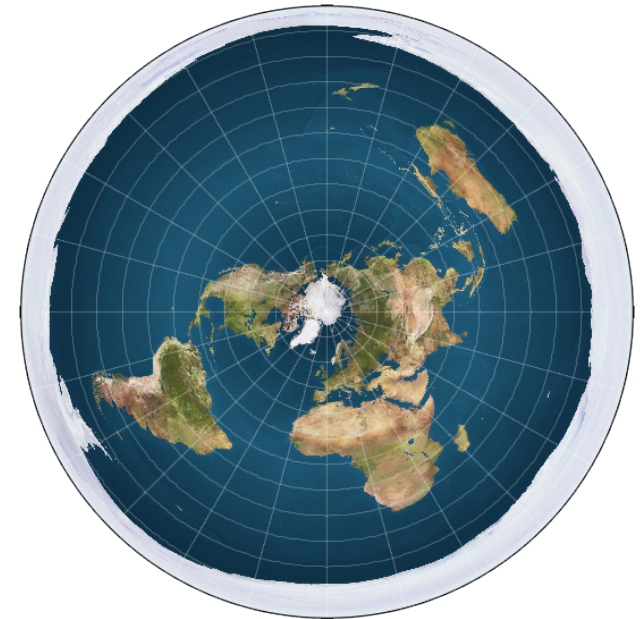
Perhaps the most famous conspiracy theory of all concerns the moon landings. In 1969, astronauts Buzz Aldrin and Neil Armstrong landed the spacecraft Apollo 11 on the moon. But to this day, conspiracy theorists maintain that this never happened. At the time, the USA and Russia were competing in the 'Space Race', an unofficial contest to see who could put someone on the moon first. Theorists believe that America, desperate to win, staged a moon landing by hiring a studio in Hollywood and faking the whole thing. The supposed giveaways are the shadows in the photos (apparently, they are in the wrong places), the Stars and Stripes flag waving when there was no wind, and a lack of stars in the sky. Hmmm.



The Flat Earth

An increasing number of people believe that, rather than being a sphere, the Earth is really a flat circle with the Arctic in the centre. Around the outside of the circle is a 150ft wall of ice which stops people falling off into space. Flat Earthers believe NASA is at the heart of this conspiracy and all satellite images and evidence are lies.

Seems legit!



An image showing how flat earth conspiracy theorists view the world.

The Missing Popstars

Could things get any more complicated? Well, for Avril Lavigne, yes. The popstar and singer of, ahem, *Complicated*, has had rumours circulating about her that she died and was replaced by

Avril Lavigne - or is it Melissa?



Photo by Lara Gonçalves (CC BY 2.0) - (Cropped)

a clone called Melissa. Fans have compared images of Avril pre- and post-2003, the year of the supposed disappearance, and apparently, they are different, although to claim this as evidence of a disappearance, murder and clone is somewhat farcical.

Paul McCartney is another musician who is the subject of the missing popstar conspiracy. Some fans believe he died in a car accident in 1966 and was replaced by a lookalike called William Shears. To fuel this theory there is a reference to Billy Shears on the Beatles' seminal album *Sgt Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band*.

The Sinister Airport

Denver International Airport cost \$4.8bn to build yet, despite this, the special 26 mile underground computerised baggage system failed and is now abandoned. Some believe this is a mammoth apocalypse shelter for world leaders. Furthermore, there are some strange works of art in the airport. These include a 32-foot-high blue horse with red glowing eyes, nicknamed Blucifer, whose creator bled to death after a piece of the sculpture fell off and severed his artery during its construction.

The New World Order

Many theorists believe that Freemasons are a group trying to take over the world. Freemasonry is a male-only secret society with a large element of ritual, special symbols, clothing and ceremony. Masons even have their own handshake so they can covertly identify each other.

Another supposed group of clandestine power grabbers are the Illuminati. Former professional footballer David Icke is a proponent of this and announced in the 1980s that he believed the world was controlled by a race of alien reptiles who can shape-shift into human form and control humanity.

Conspiracy theorist, David Icke.



Photo by Stefano Maffei (CC BY 2.0) - (Cropped)

The Assassination of JFK

November 22nd, 1963 is forever remembered as the day President John F. Kennedy was shot in the head and killed whilst driving with his wife. Lee Harvey Oswald was arrested within an hour and killed two days later in police custody by nightclub owner Jack Ruby, who claimed he didn't want Mrs Kennedy to suffer through a trial. However, most Americans do not believe the official version of events. Instead, blame is directed at the Russians, the CIA and the Mafia, with Oswald being an ill-fated scapegoat. Conspiracists claim the number of shots fired was more than the police reported and that the angle of the shot didn't appear to come from where Oswald was positioned.



President Kennedy and his wife in the motorcade, minutes before he was assassinated.